A · UNDERSTANDING THE MIND & BODY

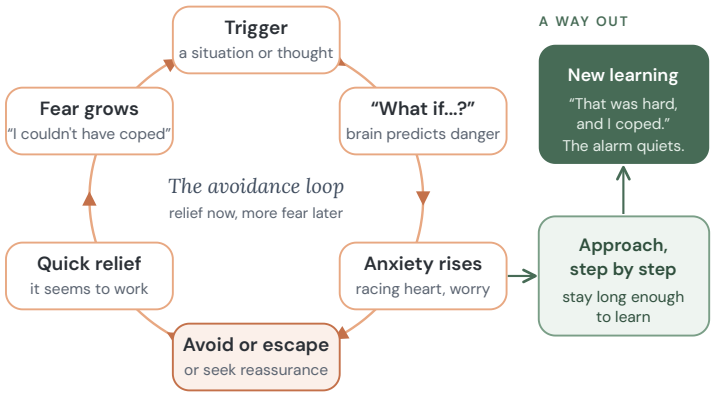
Understanding the Anxiety Cycle

Draws on cognitive behavioral therapy (CBT) and inhibitory learning research

1 WHAT IS IT?

Anxiety is the mind and body preparing for a possible threat. In the right amount it helps us prepare and stay safe. The anxiety cycle describes how avoiding what we fear brings quick relief, but over time can make anxiety stronger and our world smaller.

2 HOW DOES IT WORK?



An original illustration of how avoidance maintains anxiety, based on CBT models. Real life is messier than any diagram.

3 WHY DOES IT HAPPEN?

Your threat system is built to err on the side of caution. When anxiety spikes, avoiding, escaping, seeking reassurance, or leaning on a "safety behavior" brings fast relief. Relief is powerful: it teaches the brain that avoiding is what kept you safe.

The catch is that avoidance also blocks new learning. You never get to discover that the feared outcome didn't happen, or that you could cope if it did. So next time, the alarm rings a little louder and a little sooner.

Normal or a concern? Anxiety is a normal human emotion. It may be an anxiety disorder when it's persistent, out of proportion, hard to control, and gets in the way of work, relationships, or daily life. Anxiety disorders are very treatable.

4 WHAT CAN HELP?

Approach in small steps

Gradually facing feared situations (exposure) is one of the best-supported parts of CBT for anxiety. Start with something challenging but doable, and stay long enough to learn something new.

Notice safety behaviors

Over-preparing, checking, or asking for reassurance can quietly keep the cycle going. Try dropping one, a little at a time, and see what you discover.

Make room for the feeling

Instead of fighting a racing heart, try noticing it with curiosity: "Here's anxiety. It's uncomfortable, and I can still take the next step."

5 REFLECTION QUESTION

What has anxiety talked you out of lately, and what would one small step toward it look like?

6 KEY TAKEAWAY

Avoidance brings relief today; small, brave steps bring freedom over time.

7 REFERENCES

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Woohee (Elise) Kwak · wooheekwak.me/resources